



sports HOCKEY

LOST GLO

2008
BEIJING
FAILED TO QUALIFY

2004
ATHENS
SEVENTH

2000
SYDNEY
SEVENTH

1996
ATLANTA
EIGHTH

1992
BARCELONA
SEVENTH

1988
SEOUL
SIXTH

1984
LOS ANGELES
FIFTH

1980
MOSCOW
GOLD

1976
MONTREAL
SEVENTH

■ **By Sharda Ugra**

In the early hours of a Monday morning, separated by thousands of miles, a few good men played miserable witness. In Mumbai, injured goalkeeper Adrian D'Souza switched between the images flickering off television and his brother's online messages from the US, where he was following the match live, and not on a 10-minute delay, like D'Souza.

In Bangalore, sidelined midfielder Arjun Halappa, turned away at half-time eaten by anxiety and dread, hoping he could alter the forces of destiny by not looking.

In Perth, Ric Charlesworth, India's technical director of hockey, missed a blinding sunrise as he read line after line of

Internet commentary and knew that, on the other side of the world, something tragic and inevitable was going down.

In Santiago, Chile, coach Joaquim Carvalho stood on the sidelines and saw hope, faith and ambition slowly leak out of a team like it had been wounded.

In truth, Indian hockey has been bleeding for a few decades now but it has somehow staggered on, running mostly on empty but staying on its feet. It has had little direction, but it always had a destination. It is now knocked over, winded, its natural station de-

clared out of bounds.

The team that gave India its Olympic footprint for eight decades will be missing from the Beijing Olympics. A terse comment from the International Hockey Federation (IHF) President Els van Breda Vriesman carried its own sting. "Sport is sometimes hard but honest and only the best 12 teams in the world will participate at the Olympic Games."

India's decline in world hockey is not news anymore. Its slide in standards is evident from its Olympic results (see graphic), but this is different. India has been shut out from the one

ished." India has close to 40 astro turfs in comparison to South Korea's five and China's three, who will both be in the Beijing hockey event. India won't.

The day after the Chile cave-in, friends stopped D'Souza in his old football-hockey-crazed neighbourhood of Orlem and asked, "How could this happen?" He had no explanation. India had three medal finishes last year (see box) and once again a brave new team was being built up as Olympic contenders. But while we were looking elsewhere, Indian hockey didn't suddenly become world-beaters, it just learnt to fiddle the numbers a little.

Unlike other countries which play 40 internationals in the pre-Olympic year, India played only 17, only one of those against a top four nation. Faced with a sudden-death qualifying match against Great Britain, the 80-year uninterrupted streak would have flashed through the minds of Carvalho's young team. Long enough to interrupt them.

Indian hockey has had enough warnings: Vriesman called the Indian Hockey Federation (IHF) the worst-run national federation in the world which should have made the Government sit up. Failure to qualify for the 2006 Asian Games semi-final should have red flagged the team's difficulties, but the IHF was content with its routine window dressing: sack the coach, drop some players, pass the samosas.

The Doha finish certainly alarmed IHF which pushed through (and is partly



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RIC CHARLESWORTH, TECHNICAL DIRECTOR

event that reinvigorated its hockey every four years, that rekindled its hope and kept it relevant in a country now drawn to different leisure. This is not mere humiliation, it reads more like a notice of extermination.

A country with heritage and numbers behind it should not find itself here, wriggling in a quagmire. "There are resources in India," Charlesworth says, "thousands of players in training supported by the state, but those programmes are not focussed. The playing quality is there but it needs to be pol-